

Chapter 91-2

The memories from last night made Liang Shi need quite a while to recover. Only after her emotions had mostly calmed down did she take out her phone and switch to the chat interface with Xu Qingzhu. The topmost entry was their video call—ten minutes and fifty seconds.

Not short at all.

She poked at the screen to type: Have you arrived at the company?

—Deleted.

At this hour, she definitely wouldn't have arrived yet. She should still be driving.

She paused and typed again: Have you eaten breakfast?

—Deleted.

When she woke up just now, the sheets beside her were still warm, meaning Xu Qingzhu had only left not long ago. She probably didn't have time to eat either.

She paused again and typed: When did you leave?

—Deleted.

This question sounded very much like something asked after... that. It felt like the next sentence should be—Why aren't you taking responsibility for me?

Having watched too many romance dramas and acted in a few idol dramas herself, Liang Shi felt this wasn't appropriate.

So after struggling for a while, she got up and went to the bathroom to wash up.

She casually tied her hair into a low ponytail, simply washed her face at the small sink, and didn't use the hotel towel. Instead, she pressed tissue paper to her face to absorb the moisture. She didn't really trust the quality of this hotel's toiletries.

Even the pillow had that old wood smell.

Oh right.

Liang Shi thought of something to say as a greeting—she'd ask Xu Qingzhu if she had smelled the old wood scent on the pillow.

Xu Qingzhu had a sensitive nose and was particular about bedding hygiene. Asking her about this now should be the safest option.

But unexpectedly, when Liang Shi picked up her phone, she discovered that she had accidentally sent a period to Xu Qingzhu before locking her phone.

And Xu Qingzhu had already replied: [?]

—[You thought for five minutes and came up with this?]

Liang Shi: "..."

Her feelings were extremely mixed.

Liang Shi poked at the screen: [So you've been watching the chat box the whole time?]

Xu Qingzhu had probably just arrived at the company. She sent a voice message. The background was noisy, with the sounds of cars speeding past and people around her exchanging morning greetings. Xu Qingzhu's voice stood out distinctly among all the noise. She said: "I was going to send a message asking if you were awake, but then I saw the top kept showing 'the other party is typing,' so I waited and waited."

Those last three words were bitten out particularly clearly, and she drew out the tone, slow and light. It sounded especially like teasing.

Through the phone, Liang Shi embarrassedly pinched her ear.

Soon, Xu Qingzhu sent another message: "Just like now."

Liang Shi: "?"

"What about now?" Only when Liang Shi spoke did she realize her voice hadn't recovered yet. It still had the hoarseness of just waking up, a bit... soft and babyish.

She wanted to retract it, but Xu Qingzhu's voice message had already come through again: "Like now—I waited and waited, but you still didn't say anything."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I did say something." Liang Shi defended herself. "Remember to eat breakfast."

Xu Qingzhu: [Oh.]

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. After sitting on the edge of the bed thinking for a few seconds, she sent a voice message, carrying a hint of eager anticipation: "Let me treat you to an escape room this Saturday. I heard a new immersive escape room just opened in the north part of the city, and it's supposed to be really good."

Two seconds later, she added: [Just forget about my embarrassing behavior last night.]

Xu Qingzhu's tone carried a smile, deliberately lilting upward: "What embarrassing behavior? If you hadn't mentioned it, I would have forgotten."

Liang Shi: [...]

How could she possibly forget?!

She clearly remembered everything very well.

Liang Shi was about to send something else when Xu Qingzhu sent: [An immersive escape room? If Teacher Liang wants to make it out of the escape room unscathed, how much alcohol would that take?]

Liang Shi sent six dots to express her speechlessness.

Xu Qingzhu: [You'd probably have to drink an entire distillery dry.]

Liang Shi: [...]

Liang Shi jabbed at her screen hard: [Just you wait! I definitely won't be scared.]

In the voice message Xu Qingzhu sent back, her tone was provocative: "Really?"

Liang Shi: "Of course it's true. Whoever gets scared is a puppy!"¹

Xu Qingzhu: "Okay~"

A single word would normally be too short to send as a voice message, but Xu Qingzhu's "okay" was quite spirited—the ending was drawn out very long and carried a hint of amusement, as if mocking her.

Liang Shi's competitive spirit was ignited.

She thought: I'll definitely be able to walk out of that escape room without drinking.

It's just an escape room, right?

She didn't necessarily have to play a horror theme. She could do a puzzle-solving one.

But the system was really such a dog². Why did it have to issue that kind of mission?

Staying inseparable for 24 hours, plus going to an escape room, and coaxing Xu Qingzhu to sleep...

Whatever, no one could refuse two hundred thousand yuan.

Footnotes:

¹ **Whoever gets scared is a puppy (誰害怕誰小狗)**: A common Chinese expression used when making bets or dares, similar to "whoever chickens out is a loser." Being called a "puppy" or "dog" in this context is a playful insult suggesting cowardice.

² **The system is really such a dog (系統是真的狗)**: Chinese internet slang where calling something/someone a "dog" expresses frustration or complaint about unfair or annoying behavior. Similar to saying "the system is really something" or "the system is so mean."